

Windows Vulnerabilities

The Problem

Certain vulnerabilities in Windows have been reported, all of which can be exploited by malicious people to compromise a system. The first is a "boundary error" in the Remote Access AutoDial Helper library (rasadhlp.dll); successful exploitation allows execution of arbitrary code, for example, when a user visits a malicious Web site.

The second is errors in the DNS Client service when processing DNS responses. This can be exploited to corrupt memory, and again, successful exploitation allows execution of arbitrary code on the victim's computer.

Security firm Secunia has rated these vulnerabilities "Highly Critical," which is just one notch below their maximum alert level.

What To Do

These vulnerabilities affect many Windows versions, including XP Home and Professional, and you'll need to apply the patches, from Microsoft's Web site.

For XP with SP1 or SP2, the URL is www.microsoft.com/downloads/details.aspx?FamilyId=c332b95a-2956-406b-9e06-07c5e96b02e3 (<http://snipurl.com/secsep1>). For Windows XP Professional x64 Edition, the URL is www.microsoft.com/downloads/details.aspx?FamilyId=1be5310b-1995-4ef9-a462-04da9833f50b (<http://snipurl.com/secsep2>).

between the two, causing a short circuit. And we all know what that means—sparks, or loads of heat, at the very least. The effects range from melting battery compartments to little explosions, depending on how fast the temperature rises. The potential danger is why cars and other power tools stick to the traditional lead-acid batteries—the reaction inside the Li-ion battery is considered quite violent.

The problem isn't limited to just Dell—other vendors using the Sony battery might be at risk as well, but neither Sony nor any of the other manufacturers have seen this problem at the scale at which it has affected Dell. Sony, naturally, supports this recall and will provide financial assistance in getting the batteries back and invest in the necessary research to resolve the issue.

The news gives the evangelists for alternative batteries another arrow in their quiver, and companies are already working on either safer Li-ion batteries or batteries based on other chemicals. Zinc Matrix, for example, is working on a silver-zinc based battery that it guarantees won't explode. Production will begin in early 2007, they say, and laptops will last up to ten hours on these batteries—longer than Li-ion ones.

Meanwhile, you may want to reconsider using your laptop on your lap.

MAKE YOUR OWN GAMES

Gamers Set To Develop New Games

Hardcore gamer? Well, Microsoft is looking for you—the company has announced a new set of developer tools that will let even the average couch warrior develop his or her own game for the Xbox 360 or PC. It's called XNA Game Studio Express, and should be available in beta by the time you read this. The tool is the next step for the original XNA tools, released in March 2005, before the subsequent release of the Xbox 360 in November.

This is all part of Microsoft's conspiracy strategy to involve the community even more—much like the open beta programmes and the release of Visual Studio 2005 in a free "Express" version for hobbyists and amateur programmers. This release will enable enthusiasts to get together and make their own community-driven games and publish them. The vision behind the initiative is something like a gaming YouTube, and will probably suffer the same flaws—some exceptional content hidden by mounds of gibberish. More importantly, this might endear gamers to the Microsoft camp well before

HOT Performance Per Watt



The new buzzword as processors go, Intel is pushing for it—and seems to have forgotten about clock speeds. They're asking for performance per watt to become the new measure of processor performance.

GHZ Racers

Green is in, gigahertz is out. That's the outlook. No more clamouring for 4 and 5 GHz. Power-efficient, multi-core chips could help spawn smaller, quieter machines. Intel's leading the way, and how long will it be before AMD catches on?



its competitors—the PS3 and the Wii—come to play spoilsport.

Initially, a \$99 fee will induct you into the temporarily-called "Creators' Club", and your games will only be playable within this community. In about three or five years, this club will go open, leading to an open game publishing model.

If the idea takes off, we're going to see a horde of new talent, and the open model will ensure that even crazy, off-beat titles will see the light of day—right now game publishers only want to back games they're sure will make it, what with the huge budgets and eons of development that go into new games.

One Silly Question

"What would you replace your mouse with?"



"A miniature girl!"
Edison Thomas



"I'd use my fingers"
Shoma Bhowmick



"A ball..."
Manoj Singh



"A rat, of course!"
Swati Jain



"How about a steering wheel?"
Siddhartha Saha